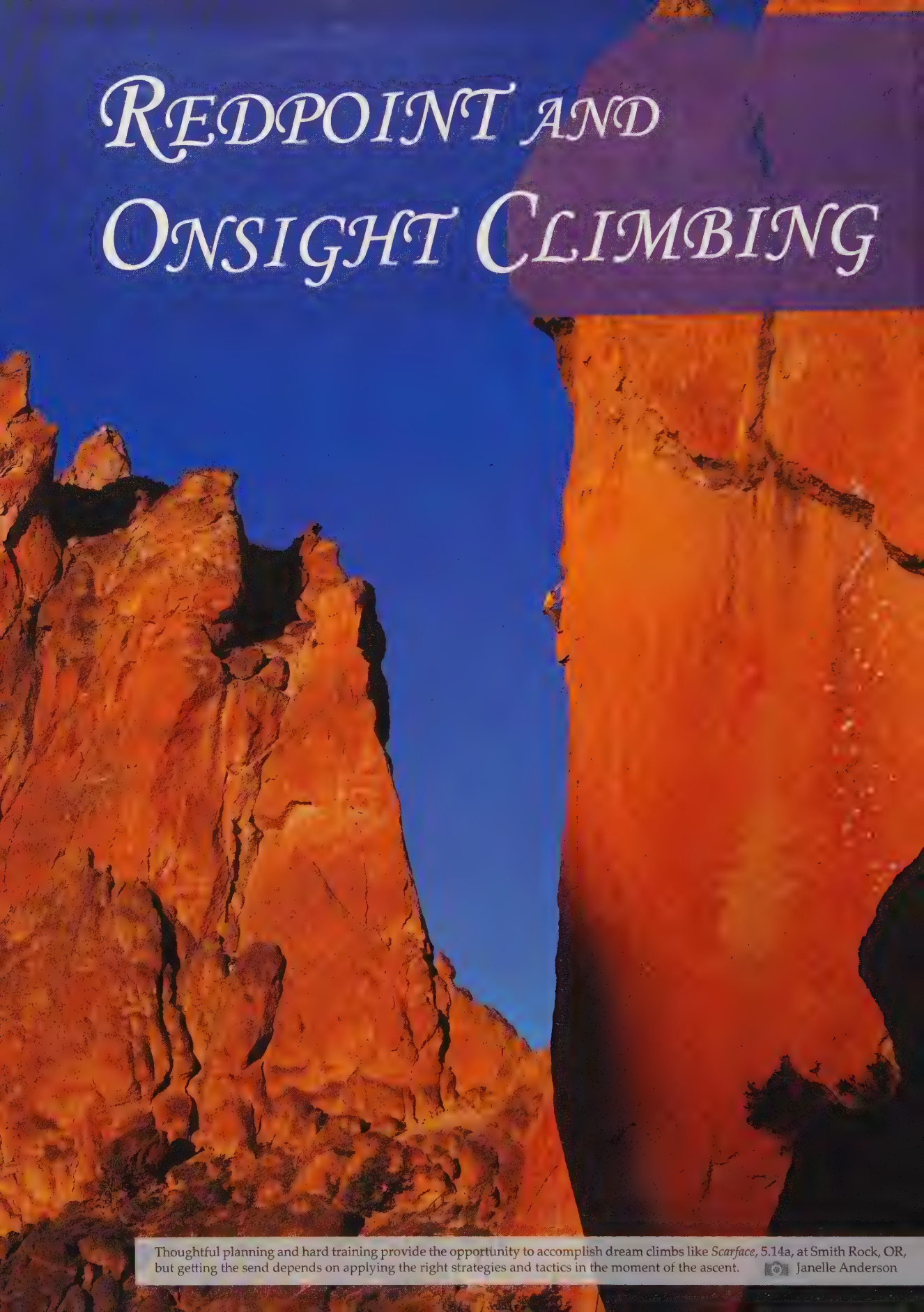


REDPOINT AND ONSIGHT CLIMBING

A full-page photograph of a red rock climbing wall. The rock is a deep orange-red color, with visible cracks and textures. The sky above is a clear, deep blue. The lighting suggests it's either early morning or late afternoon, with the sun low on the horizon, casting a warm glow on the rock.

Thoughtful planning and hard training provide the opportunity to accomplish dream climbs like *Scarface*, 5.14a, at Smith Rock, OR, but getting the send depends on applying the right strategies and tactics in the moment of the ascent.  Janelle Anderson

CHAPTER 13

“Long and successful climbing careers are like wars. Few people get to the other end without giving up or slowing down because they can’t get past the many small failures and get back up and keep going until the success finally arrives.”

— Dave MacLeod⁶

By the time a climber boots up at the base of his dream route, the outcome has largely been determined by the work he accomplished to prepare for that attempt. The route choice itself and the timing of the moment reflect this preparation — both are the result of careful research and planning. Crafting an effective plan and working hard by following through with the training are the most effective ways for a climber to achieve future success. Training effort is like compounding interest, multiplying its value over time, producing long-term improvement that could never be realized otherwise.

Nevertheless, for a climber to reach his highest potential requires the appropriate application of effort in the moment of the ascent. Not the *maximum* effort — the *appropriate* effort, because success usually hinges on the ability to ration effort along the climb, reigning in strength and power whenever possible so that both are available to unleash where they are most needed. This applies to the route-projecting process as much as it applies to the eventual redpoint. Careful application of physical effort, time, skin, and belayer patience is required to discover the keys to the route in time for a worthy redpoint attempt. In this chapter, this delicate and critical balancing act will be explored in detail for short-term redpoints, long-term redpoints, and onsight ascents.

STRATEGY FOR A SHORT-TERM REDPOINT

Not every route worth climbing requires a long, protracted siege to send, and there are numerous reasons for climbers to pursue routes below their absolute limit. Recall from [Chapter 2: Goal Setting and Planning](#) and [Chapter 3: Skill Development](#) that long-term improvement is best achieved through the pursuit of near-limit, *short-term redpoints* that can be sent in three to four days. In addition, the length of a road trip may dictate a short-duration project. The perfect example is a quick trip to a faraway crag with a particular classic route on the agenda that is unlikely to be onsighted, but may be completed in one to three days, if all goes well. Finally, not every goal route is at the climber’s absolute limit, but sending it in personal record time can be a worthy challenge.

PLANNING THE CAMPAIGN

Short-term, near-limit redpoints pose unique challenges, so the strategy and tactics used should be modified accordingly. With limited time, energy, and even skin, each burn becomes more precious, so good planning is essential. First consider how many days are available and develop a plan for which days to climb, the time of day to climb, and when to rest, taking into account the weather, shade, sunrise, and sunset. The primary calculus when developing this plan is the tradeoff between working the route to learn and refine moves, and resting sufficiently to execute the redpoint. Working the route is very taxing, especially on a new project in which the climber can expect to consume energy and skin repeatedly attempting moves incorrectly before refining the beta. The “Weekend Plans” sidebar details how to make the most of a short trip.

Weekend Plans

The best way to optimize a climbing weekend is a classic debate among climbers, on par with “*Did Mallory reach the summit of Everest?*” This is a no-brainer for many, who just climb until failure every day, but the wily veterans know better. Climbing straight through a long weekend typically results in deteriorating performance, with the best day (the first one) “wasted” on learning the beta for the project. Over many three-day weekends my partner has ridiculed me for resting on the second day, only to burn himself out early on the third day, citing wrecked skin and overwhelming fatigue. We both wound up climbing the same amount (two days), but I had the advantage of a rest day between my climbing days.

For difficult climbing, the goal should be to fit in as many *high-quality* climbing sessions as possible. Sessions stacked atop each other without rest are not high quality. Also, working burns early in a campaign are more taxing because the most difficult moves are climbed repeatedly and often inefficiently at first. Therefore, more rest is called for early in the process. To maximize a weekend, take into consideration how much time is available, and the travel time to the crag. The coveted three-day weekend will afford two high-quality climbing days and a full rest day, while a two-day weekend may require climbing two days consecutively. If an early Friday arrival is possible, consider a Friday-evening climbing session, followed by a Saturday rest day, thus enabling a high-quality climbing day on Sunday (with beta) to send.

Breaking the days up into early-morning and late-evening sessions (so, resting midday) is a good strategy in the summer when days are long and midday heat is an issue. An effective strategy for a two-day summer weekend is to climb Saturday morning and Sunday afternoon (assuming shade is available), which allows for 24-plus hours of rest. Alpine starts aren’t just for mountain climbers — don’t be afraid to wake up *early* for the best conditions. Some of my most memorable sends came after a 4 a.m. wakeup call! A midday siesta will let you catch up on the rest you missed, and make better use of the entire weekend. Four-day weekends are like gold, and climbing on days one, three, and four will yield the highest-quality sessions.

— Mike Anderson

LEARNING THE ROUTE

Once on the route, a different calculus occurs: determining how much effort and time to spend learning each move, and what mysteries to save for the redpoint. A primary assumption is that the route is *near* the climber’s limit, but not *at* the limit, which implies that a flawless effort is not required to send; the climber can afford to make a few mistakes or figure out certain moves on the fly. With unlimited time, a climber would do well to ruthlessly rehearse every move, but that is neither practical nor necessary for a short-term redpoint. Considering the entire route, the climber should assess each section and prioritize them by difficulty. Plan to spend the majority of rehearsal time and effort on the hardest sections while assuming some risk on the easier sections by under-rehearsing them.

THE FIRST BURN

On the first burn, it is imperative to attempt every move on the route, clear to the chains. The goal of this burn is primarily to understand the nature of the route: where the cruxes are, how difficult they are, where recovery will be possible, and ultimately if a redpoint is feasible in the time available. Besides that, the climber just might send on the second burn, and a minimal survey of every move gives him a fighting chance. Making it to the chains may require working moves less thoroughly, but there will be plenty of time for a more in-depth reconnaissance while lowering from the anchor or during the next burn. This first-burn “recon” helps the climber characterize the route and its challenges (a distinct crux, multiple cruxes with rests, or an endurance test), and informs his strategy going forward.

THE SECOND BURN

On a short-term redpoint, every subsequent burn (and possibly the first as well) should begin as a redpoint attempt, because you never know what might happen — you just might send! Once a fall occurs, the climber can lower and pull the rope if necessary to work the route properly. A possible exception to this rule would be a route with a high crux or one that features very pumpy, draining climbing that the climber clearly needs to rehearse before he is ready to redpoint. The second working burn should focus primarily on deciphering the cruxes. Work the hardest moves early in the burn, when most fresh, so you can apply maximum effort. Avoid doggedly repeating a single move over and over, especially on routes with small

holds and/or sharp rock. This focuses wear and tear on the skin, and risks a devastating flapper in a location that coincides with a critical crux hold — apply tape proactively to prevent these injuries. If the move is troubling and tape won't solve the problem, come back to it later in the burn or later in the day, allowing your skin a chance to recover.

LEARNING THE MOVES

Lower cruxes require less refinement because a fall low on the route during a redpoint attempt is not devastating — the climber can quickly lower to the ground and restart. On the other hand, a fatiguing redpoint burn that fails high on the route will require lengthy recovery. Therefore, spend more effort dialing higher cruxes, including *redpoint cruxes* (cruxes high on the route that wouldn't otherwise be limiting, but become so because they are reached when you're already highly fatigued). With the upper sections wired, the lower cruxes can be approached with a boulderer's mentality — attempting low cruxes from the ground on redpoint, lowering back down between attempts, and continuing to the top when you eventually overcome these cruxes. This approach balances the effort between rehearsal and performance, so that during the redpoint attempts, the higher the climber gets

and the more fatigued he gets, the more practice and confidence he should have with the remaining moves.

The easiest sections of the route need not be ruthlessly wired, but they should be rehearsed in a manner that doesn't expend energy unnecessarily. The warm-up or cooldown can be spent lapping easy sections of the project rather than using that effort and skin on an unrelated route. Easier sections near the ground would be best for the warm-up, while higher stretches would be best to rehearse as a cooldown (sometimes it is possible to hang a toprope from an adjacent route in order to warm up on a high, easy run to the chains, or the climber might stick-clip up to that point). If there is any possibility whatsoever of blowing a redpoint attempt on the “easy run to the chains,” it must be rehearsed thoroughly, including rest positions. The propensity to fail high on a route varies by climber, so if this is a common problem for you, pay extra attention to the final sequence of moves.

MENTAL REHEARSAL

Mental rehearsal and visualization are powerful tools that are essential for conserving energy and skin during short-term projects, when beta must be memorized quickly. When lowering after every burn, pause often to recall, visualize, and memorize sequences



The challenge of a short term redpoint campaign is to learn the moves quickly. Pause regularly to mentally rehearse the sequences while lowering after each burn.  Andrew Burr

(remember, when climbing, the handholds will be viewed from below, so visualize them from a similar angle). Utilize the downtime between burns and rest days to mentally rehearse the project from the base of the route. See **Chapter 12: Preparing to Perform** for recommended visualization techniques.

RECOVERY

Because of the time constraints facing short-term redpoints, it is critical to recover quickly between burns and between climbing days. Good recovery begins early, by adequately refueling throughout the climbing day to restore muscle glycogen supplies. Eat recovery foods, and examine and treat skin between each burn throughout the climbing day. Once the hard climbing is done for the day, enhance the recovery process by performing a thorough cooldown, stretching, and then icing as described in “Cooldown” in **Chapter 12: Preparing to Perform**.

GOING FOR THE REDPOINT

Once the sequences are unlocked, it is time to attempt a redpoint (actually, it's not uncommon to attempt a redpoint on the first try). When a redpoint burn ends in a fall, the climber faces another decision of whether or not to work the route, or lower immediately to conserve resources for the next burn. *In general, the climber should work the route after each unsuccessful burn, continuing to the chains to ensure that the climb's highest, most fatiguing sections are also the best rehearsed.* Adopting an attitude that the climber will surely send on the “next try,” and then lowering to the ground without additional practice, usually prolongs the project. This approach is rarely justified, unless it is the last burn of the trip.

Immediately after a fall, analyze the attempt. Don't focus solely on the point where the fall occurred; often, falls result from errors made lower on the route. Instead, review the entire performance, noting all sequences that were climbed inefficiently, or points of hesitation or uncertainty about the proper sequence. A simple mental rehearsal with miming may be adequate for sequences that were unclear or climbed hesitantly. On the other hand, the climber must physically rehearse cruxes that depend on subtle details, such as how the holds are gripped, foot location and placement, hip position, and the timing of movements. If any of these details are unresolved, lower down and rehearse them (reposition the rope if necessary). Finally, be sure to brush or otherwise clean any key holds while lowering off the route.

If all goes well, you'll soon be sipping champagne around the campfire, but don't use this metric to judge the value of the experience. Whether or not the effort results in a send, working through the process will expand your sphere of experience and knowledge, increasing the likelihood of success on the next campaign.

STRATEGY FOR A LONG-TERM REDPOINT

A *long-term redpoint* is any project that takes more than a week's worth of climbing days to complete. Some such projects can take entire seasons, multiple seasons, or even multiple years to complete. Projects of this length can be intimidating, but they can also be extremely rewarding. These campaigns test the boundaries of one's physical and mental abilities, requiring extreme fitness, commitment, and perseverance.

Generally speaking, long, protracted sieges should be used sparingly. They can be the ace card for ascending a lifelong goal route, but they are normally not the best path to steady improvement. Imagine two climbers, one who spends three straight seasons working one 80-foot route with 50 moves. His buddy works and sends three routes per season of roughly the same length. The climber who chose shorter-term projects will be exposed to roughly nine times more sequences, a wider variety of rock types, and many different styles of climbing. The climber who chose to invest the entire year on one project will learn a great deal about the strategic and mental aspects of climbing performance, but he won't learn many new moves, and will be exposed to a relatively narrow selection of climbing styles and physical challenges over the same time period.

By this point it should be apparent that, for the purpose of achieving continuous improvement, training is preferable to climbing. Eventually every protracted project devolves to a point of training on the route. While this strategy may result in a send in the fewest number of calendar days, it wastes countless climbing days — days that could be spent sending other quality lines, while fitness and skill continue to steadily improve. In the long run, it usually makes more sense to stay on the path of continuous improvement and return to the lifelong goal route when it can be climbed in fewer days.

Regardless, sooner or later most climbers will benefit from working a route that is a reach for their climbing ability. Such experiences are tremendously inspiring, require the climber to raise her game through dedicated training, and can produce substantial personal growth, humility, and, ultimately, improved confidence.

PLANNING

Committing to a project that could span multiple years is no simple matter. This leap should be well-considered. A cavalier attitude usually results in a lack of commitment. A long-term project requires uncommon determination and perseverance, which are difficult to apply without a strong commitment to the process. The first step is to decide if such a project is desirable. Good reasons to make the leap are a lack of inspiring shorter-term options within the climber's target zone (routes that can usually be sent in six days or less), or proximity to a particularly inspiring line that is barely within reach (such as a lifelong goal route). Err on the side of spacing such campaigns too far apart, allowing at least a year's worth of near-limit (short-term) projecting in between. Consider how this project might affect potential partners. Are they willing to visit the same crag day-in and day-out for multiple seasons? Discuss this with the affected parties and make sure the entire team is supportive.

Selecting the objective is a big decision, one to be taken after careful consideration. This route will be the object of obsession for a long time, so it should be worthy of your full attention. If possible, reconnoi-

ter the potential candidates to determine which line is most suitable. This is usually not the time to work weaknesses, but rather to favor routes that play to your strengths. The route should be fun and enjoyable to climb on. A move that feels a bit painful on day one will feel downright gnarly on day 20. Geography can be a big factor — a nearby route can be worked more frequently. Also, consider the general weather conditions — routes with narrow windows of good weather will lead to frustration. Ultimately, the line must be inspiring. The ensuing effort to climb this route will put all previous accomplishments to shame, so the route must produce unequaled amounts of motivation to get the climber through the months (and sometimes years) of training that will be required to succeed.

Once the objective is defined, the fun can begin. If an initial recon was not conducted, do some research on the route to uncover as much information as possible about the style of climbing, physical attributes and abilities required to send it, and the best times of year to attempt the route. Develop a long-term plan for the campaign, including a rough estimate of how long it is expected to take. Count the days out on a calendar to get an idea of how many weeks or seasons will be required, but don't expect everything to turn out according to the plan. (While it varies considerably by climber, a good rule of thumb can be to triple the amount of time spent on a project for each letter-grade increase in difficulty. Thus if 13a takes three days, 13b might take nine, and 13c, 27!)

The Seasonal Training Plan should be developed such that the Performance Phase coincides with the

Genetic Drifter, 5.14c, Wild Iris, WY, was the ideal long-term project for BJ Tilden, being a dream route at his local crag. He made the second ascent in 2009 after many years of concerted effort.  Chuck Fryberger



ideal climbing conditions for the goal route. For a geographically distant project, it may make sense to make an initial visit early in the year to learn the character of the route, followed by another season of training dedicated specifically to that route, and then finally a return trip to send. If specifics about the crux moves are known, consider augmenting the training plan to target these moves, particularly if they exploit a known weakness (for example, if the crux requires the use of a mono pocket, incorporate this grip into the Strength Phase). If possible, construct boulder problems on a home wall that replicate crux moves.

WHERE TO BEGIN?

A long-term project will begin much like any other: with the climber confident the send will materialize much sooner than it actually does! These efforts are ultimately a test of will. Like any project, with sufficient rehearsal, the moves will eventually become familiar enough that they can be linked on redpoint. The real question is whether the climber can sustain motivation long enough to see the process through to the end. It may help to begin each season with one or two short-term projects to inspire confidence and provide a pseudo “insurance policy” on the season, because the gratification of sending the long-term project could be a long time coming.

A beyond-limit project will be intimidating upon initial inspection. While strategies for short-term redpointing demand previewing every move on the first burn, the climber will be lucky to attempt every move of a long-term project on the first *day* (and many of the moves will likely feel impossible). Begin by separating the route into sections that can be dealt with individually. Have faith that eventually the sequences can be linked, but first focus on simply identifying the most efficient way to climb the individual sequences. Consider each section like its own boulder problem, with the initial goal to send ten (or however many) individual boulder problems.

FOCUS ON THE PROCESS

When working a long-term redpoint, focus on the process. The detailed process of discovering and refining beta is not much different than for any other project; the difference is that these steps will take much more time, so it will be necessary to set modest goals for each burn or climbing day. Every crag day should begin with a clear set of goals for that day. These should include some performance goals (for example, “attempt to climb from the ground to the chains with

two hangs or less” or “send the crux on lead”), but also some goals that are achievable regardless of performance (such as, “rehearse the moves between the fourth and sixth bolts” or “find a better clipping stance for the seventh bolt”). Weekends, or sets of climbing days, should begin with clear goals as well. For a multi-season project, the goal for the first season might simply be to climb all of the individual moves.

Climbers will want to focus most of their energy and attention on the crux sequences initially. These sequences will require the most time to “learn down,” so get an early start. It makes little sense to dial the moderate entry moves if the crux is impossible. That said, small victories can go a long way, so save some time each day to enjoy the easier moves. Attempt the most powerful sections earlier in the day (or burn), and save the easier moves for later. As the moves come together, explore how best to exploit the rest stances, then spend time rehearsing the easier moves to save energy for the cruxes.

Long-term projects require repetitive use of specific body positions and holds, so repetitive stress injuries are possible. Limit the number of attempts per day on moves that use tweeky or otherwise threatening body positions, and limit the use of extremely sharp holds to avoid damaging skin. Often the early days of a limit project will be completely exhausting, as the moves are rarely climbed in the most efficient manner, and must be attempted repeatedly. Early in the process you should plan extra rest days and limit the length of burns (use a stopwatch if necessary). As the beta starts to come together, there will be ample time to run to the chains on every burn.

MAINTAINING MOTIVATION

The difference between success and failure often boils down to motivation, because the desired result (a redpoint ascent) is often too distant to be motivating. To the contrary, simply contemplating the redpoint, as far off as it feels, can be overwhelming and demoralizing. If the climber can stay psyched long enough to see the process through, success is likely. The best way to maintain motivation is to enjoy the process of learning and embrace the present challenge. Unfortunately, many projecting climbers develop a vague schedule for their project, which then becomes a cruel source of frustration. As soon as the rate of progress exceeds this arbitrary schedule, the climber is elated; and whenever it lags behind, he is disappointed. Rather than obsessing over imaginary deadlines, focus on making progress each day. Be satisfied with each new



Motivation is essential for any long-term project, including that of the belayer(s). A faraway route, and/or a long approach will increase the pressure, as Jason Haas learned on his remote route *Question Your Progression*, 5.14a, South Platte, CO. 📷 Ben Schneider

opt to work a long-term project concurrently with other short-term projects or onsights in order to spread out the physical and mental wear and tear, and hedge their bets. Mixing in other climbing can buoy self-esteem, prevent de-training, and relieve belayers, but there are downsides. At a minimum, this approach extends the length of the project, but even worse, the lack of commitment often leads to a loss of focus and eventual abandonment of the long-term project. Consider these factors when deciding how to approach a long-term project.

THE END GAME

Once the redpoint is within sight, it may be beneficial to alter your mindset slightly. By this point, the best warm-up climbs should be identified — those that are enjoyable, don't aggravate skin or other ailing body parts, and prepare the mind and body to perform at their peak. Professional athletes often describe *the grind* as a consistent routine that can reliably produce peak performance while minimizing stress. Climbers can use this approach by accomplishing every task in the same order, using this routine to build a sense of calm confidence in anticipation of the impending challenge.

At this point, it's common for anxiety to build up as a result of all the hours and days that have gone into the effort. Remain focused on the learning process, approaching each day as another opportunity to learn and improve, rather than hoping that today is the day. Take every step as it comes, and eventually the right opportunity to send will present itself.

Most successful long-term projects involve one or two near misses, where the climber fails on a relatively easy move when it seems the ascent was in the bag. While not ideal, these near successes are not the end of the world either (if the climber reached that point once, he can do it again). Entering the process with an acceptance that this may happen can reduce the immediate stress that comes when the climber finally sends through the crux, or surpasses a previous high point. Be pleased with the new progress, rather than worried about the coming sequence. Either way the day has proven successful, so continue with focus and the knowledge that there is "nothing to lose." Overconfidence can sour the experience and distract the climber from focusing on the climbing at hand.

bit of information that is discovered, and revel in every new high point or improved link.

In addition to setting intermediate goals that provide opportunities to achieve periodic success, strive to make the process fun. Climb with friends who keep the mood light, savor the hike to the cliff, and take time to climb fun moderates every now and then. There will be plenty of time to stress out over the outcome down the road, so enjoy the growth process for as long as possible. Watch inspiring climbing videos, or read a hero's autobiography on rest days to maintain psych.

It may be helpful to take a break from the project occasionally to onsight routes at another crag, climb a multipitch route, or enjoy some non-climbing recreation. Find an activity that breaks up the routine and gives the mind a chance to reset. A well-timed break will have the climber itching to get back to her project at the next possible opportunity. Many climbers

LIVE TO FIGHT ANOTHER DAY

Occasionally the selected project is simply too hard (for now). Endlessly persisting under such conditions is no fun, but even worse, it won't help the climber improve. Sometimes it makes sense to "cut bait" and focus energy on other routes or additional training. One method of informing this decision is to consider how much time is budgeted for the total campaign, and then strive to hit certain milestones within a percentage of that time. The specifics will vary depending on the nature of the route (powerful vs. pumpy, etc.), but generally one might expect to have done all of the individual moves by the end of the first quarter, linked the route in three or four sections by halftime, and one-hanged the route by the end of the third quarter. If the climber is five days into a ten-day trip and still

can't do several moves, it might make sense to move on (or start planning a return trip).

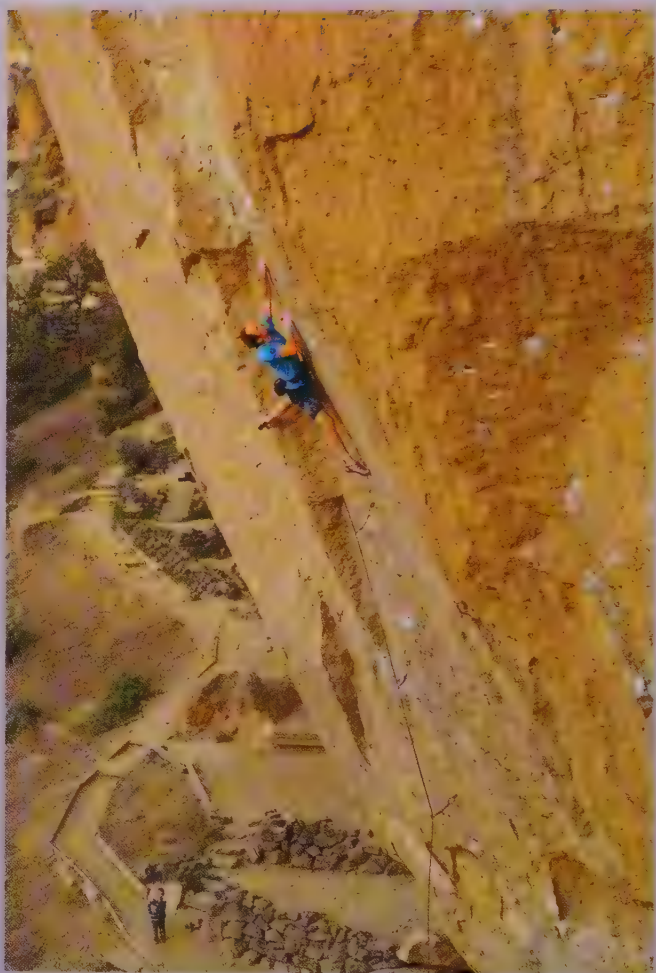
External influences can provide additional decision points. Shifts in weather, significant skin issues, an aching joint, fatigue of partners and family, or waning fitness can all provide opportune moments to re-evaluate the strategy. Once all the moves are known, steady progress should come in the form of increasingly longer links and fewer hangs on the rope. As long as the climber is still making progress (at least every other day) and remains motivated, it often makes sense to continue. When in the throes of a long-term project, climbing efficiency typically improves as physical fitness wanes. Once waning fitness outpaces efficiency, progress will stagnate or even regress. If the climber is consistently failing in the same locations,

Two Years and 14 Days

I first attempted Scarface in the spring of 2005. I spent five days working the route, and at the end of the week there were still several tweaky pocket moves I couldn't do. Clearly I was not strong enough for the route, but I was inspired by this thrilling line and determined to climb it someday. I added a few more pocket grips to my strength-training program, but otherwise went about my normal business of working and sending projects closer to home. Scarface remained in the back of my mind, providing inspiration during monotonous training sessions.

In spring 2006 I returned to Scarface, and this time I did all of the moves on the first day, despite the twelve-month hiatus. I was stunned. I made much more progress that week (including several "two-hang" ascents), but now that I had the strength to do each move, it became clear that I lacked the power-endurance to link them.

Again I returned home, and focused on improving. That year I sent several memorable routes, including my hardest redpoint to that point. Early in my preparations for the spring 2007 season, I created a Linked Bouldering Circuit (modeled after the moves on Scarface) to improve my power-endurance. On my first day back on Scarface I matched my previous best, and three days later, I sent it — my first 5.14. It was nice to tick Scarface, but the redpoint was insignificant compared to the improvements that were inspired by my desire to climb it.



A dream route like *Scarface* can inspire us to elevate our climbing. Like a distant beacon, it guides our training, and motivates us daily to work harder.



Mike Anderson

— Mark Anderson

day after day, it may be a sign that he has reached this threshold of declining performance. When tangible progress on the route reaches this plateau, it usually makes sense to reconsider the approach.

As discussed above, attempting to train on the project route to regain waning fitness is not ideal. A better long-term strategy is to return to the optimal training venue (usually the gym), redouble your efforts to improve as a climber, and then return to the project in a few months or a year. The knowledge gained during the process is equally valuable whether it results in a redpoint or not. Many times a climber returning to a route after a long layoff will discover more-efficient sequences that had previously gone unnoticed. Approaching the project a second time, with fresh energy, skin, and fitness, is often the quickest path to success. Finally, one of the great aspects of this sport is that the route will always be there to climb. The knowledge discovered during the initial campaign, along with the realization that a valued send is close at hand, can be used to inspire the next round of training, resulting in significantly improved fitness and a much more productive campaign the next time around.

ONSIGHT CLIMBING

To many, onsighting represents the pinnacle of climbing mastery. An onsight ascent is one in which the climber leads a climb successfully without prior rehearsal on the route, or specific information about the climbing. An onsighting climber will not know where a route's cruxes lie, or what moves are typically used to surmount them. He won't know anything beyond what he can presume from the ground. An onsight is the purest form of ascent, with no stylistic compromises — no hangdogging, rehearsing, or borrowing beta. Onsight climbing transcends the sub-disciplines of climbing. Be they trads, rads, or pebble-wrestlers, all climbers respect the onsight ascent because it is the ultimate test of climber versus the rock.

"To me onsight climbing is the ultimate, the perfection; it's putting it all together and making the best ascent you can on a route." — Lynn Hill⁴

In many ways, onsight climbing demands the most from the climber, and the most preparation. An onsight ascent is to a redpoint as a street fight is to a choreographed Hollywood fight scene. The onsight climber must react to the situation as it unfolds, bobbing and weaving, if you will, to navigate the punches thrown by his opponent in real time. Without prior knowledge of the route ahead, the onsight climber has little time to contemplate strategies and engineer the perfect sequence. The onsight climber must immediately execute whichever to-be-determined movement skills are required for the ascent, so whatever skills he needs, he must carry with him — hanging from the rope to acquire new ones is not an option. As such, the wise onsight climber will cultivate a broad set of climbing skills and the ability to deploy them at a moment's notice, ideally as a subconscious reflex. While a redpoint climb can be (and often is) selected to hide a climber's weaknesses, that tactic is unreliable for onsighting. An onsight climber with a glaring weakness might get lucky a few times by happening upon climbs that don't expose it, but he cannot rely on this good fortune to continue forever.

Is it an Onsight or a Flash?

Opinions vary on how much prior-knowledge about a route is acceptable for an ascent to earn the lofty title of *onsight*. Some hardliners argue that even knowing the grade is TMI (too much information), but most climbers accept that it is reasonable to know the grade and path of the climbing. Many modern guidebooks give away more details than that, such as the location and relative difficulty of crux sections, or even specific moves or rests ("kneebar at the fifth bolt..."). My own rule of thumb is that any information about a route that appears in the printed guidebook (that is generally available to anyone) is fair game. I've made this decision because it's impractical for me to ignore an entire guidebook to a favorite area merely to avoid reading route descriptions or viewing topos of routes I may want to onsight someday. However, I will avoid reading lengthy Internet-posted route descriptions such as those found on MountainProject.com or similar websites. In the end, unless the international media is logging your ascents, it's likely that only you and your crew really care about what you call an onsight. Therefore, as with all stylistic "rules" of sport climbing, each climber must define his or her own standards.

— Mike Anderson



When onsighting, the climber must be prepared to execute any move the route throws at him, as Greg Kerzhner discovers on *Ride the Lightning*, 5.13b at the New River Gorge, WV. 📷 Dan Brayack

Obtaining the physical fitness and broad repertoire of skills is one challenge to mastering onsight climbing. The other, more elusive skill is developing the ideal samurai-like state of mental arousal needed for difficult onsights. This preferred state is a mix of calm relaxation and heightened awareness that allows the climber to control the unconscious workings of his body and absorb a mass of information from the environment. It enables the climber to retrieve any skill that might be required or to generate a sudden herculean effort. While the challenges of onsight climbing are largely mental, there are key physical demands that are distinct from redpoint climbing. The following section will address these unique challenges, and how to develop the skills (mental and physical) to overcome them.

“What makes climbing so great is that its rules are not given from human beings, they are given from nature, so there are as many possibilities as there are rocks on this planet.”

— Fred Nicole³

SKILL DEVELOPMENT FOR ONSIGHT CLIMBING

The most fundamental step to improving at onsight climbing is to develop a repertoire of climbing skills, as discussed in detail in **Chapter 3: Skill Development**. In redpoint climbing, any necessary skill that a climber lacks or is deficient in can be learned or improved during the route-rehearsal process. For onsight climbing, a wide array of climbing skills must be developed in advance. While it is best to acquire completely new skills in a low-stress gym environment, the goal of the onsight climber should be to strengthen existing skills such that they can be applied to various outdoor climbing situations, and eventually the high-stress environment of an onsight. Proven methods for strengthening these skills are presented in **Chapter 3**.

PHYSICAL TRAINING VARIATIONS

Onsight climbing places different physical demands on the body than redpoint climbing does. A potential limit onsight route will be of an easier technical grade than a limit redpoint, thus the holds will generally be larger or closer together, the route less steep, etc. The largest difference may be the length of time it takes to climb the route. A well-rehearsed redpoint may last a few minutes or less, while a lengthy onsight could take dozens of minutes. A redpoint may contain less demanding sections that are climbed at a slow pace, but the crux sections will nearly always be climbed at a much faster pace than is possible during an onsight. Onsight climbing will generally involve these physical variations:

- Slower pace
- Larger holds
- Climbing more statically
- Longer duration
- Recovering from difficult climbing at poor rests
- Downclimbing difficult moves

While this may sound overwhelming, the good news is that many of these traits can be developed through training exercises that are already part of the Rock Prodigy program. Most of these traits relate to local

forearm endurance, and thus are best trained through the same exercises used to develop forearm endurance for redpoint climbing, with slight adjustments to better suit the unique demands of onsight climbing. The ultimate physical training for onsight climbing is Base-Fitness Training, where many of the necessary skills can be developed concurrently. As a matter of necessity, the lion's share of climbing during an onsight attempt will take place below the Maximum Steady State (MSS), with only short, infrequent bursts above it to surpass crux moves.

The standard ARC workouts described in **Chapter 5: Base-Fitness** can be used to train for onsighting, but emphasis should be placed on climbing at a slower pace and with a less-dynamic style. Lock-off exercises can be used, such as hovering over each handhold for one to two seconds before grabbing it to simulate searching for holds on an onsight attempt. In addition, downclimbing can easily be practiced while ARCing, but you should emphasize downclimbing more difficult moves than might otherwise be downclimbed in your typical ARC session. The terrain used for ARCing should match, as nearly as possible, the terrain of the onsight goal routes in terms of angle, hold density, and type. It is essential to develop the ability to rest at poor stances and recover by actively climbing, which can also be trained while ARCing.

The following *recovery drill* is a good exercise for onsight training. Begin the drill as for a standard ARC workout, with at least 10 minutes of moderate-intensity traversing to ensure that the MSS has been reached. Once in the ARC zone, climb a more difficult boulder problem that forces you beyond the MSS, but without spitting you off the wall. After completing this crux, assume a demanding rest position and then shake out as necessary to return below the MSS. Once recovered, continue ARCing for a period of time, and then repeat the drill. Alternatively, rather than shaking out at a stationary rest stance, the climber may continue climbing on easier terrain and practice recovering through the act of climbing — an essential skill for overhanging climbs. Typically this *moving recovery* will involve climbing quite slowly with forced breathing, shaking each arm briefly between each move. Moving recovery requires a loose grip — as loose as possible without falling off — so intense concentration should be focused on relaxing the grip as much as possible and placing maximum weight on the feet. Breathe deeply to slow the heart rate and restore the calm that may have been lost during the crux section. The recovery terrain for this exercise may need to be easier than typical ARC terrain for the climber. Alternate between stationary and moving recovery during onsight-training sessions.

The Rock Prodigy program can be tailored to favor onsight climbing performance by adjusting the training in terms of pace, hold size, and duration, as well as by practicing crucial onsighting skills like recovering at taxing rest positions. 📷 Mike Anderson



Initially, these exercises should be done on a bouldering wall, where easy and hard terrain can be easily identified, crux sections can be pre-rehearsed, and tricky rest stances can be created. Rests should place significant strain on the arms, so avoid stems, ledges, or good kneebars. Instead, rests should be on steep terrain with positive handholds that require the climber to recover under load by using a relaxed grip, weighting the feet as much as possible, and alternately shaking each arm.

As the climber progresses, these exercises should be performed in lead-climbing situations, adding an element of stress that better simulates real-world onsighting scenarios. It may require some pre-planning and trial and error to locate the desired terrain. In a climbing gym, where routes of varying difficulty are set on top of (or very near) each other, consider using parts of multiple climbs. For example, on a gently overhanging wall, you might up- and downclimb the “blue route,” a juggy 5.10, for ten minutes to get established at the MSS, then (without switching ropes or moving) climb the crux of the “yellow route,” a crimpy 5.11+, before switching back to the “blue route.” This approach multiplies the route-climbing options available. This technique can be used to a lesser extent on the rock. Two closely spaced routes can be mixed and matched to add or remove cruxes, or an easier route can be climbed as an eliminate — deliberately skipping certain holds — to modulate the difficulty of the climbing as needed for the workout.

While a majority of onsight climbing will take place below the MSS, on limit onsights the climber will inevitably call on his power-endurance (PE) for portions of the climb. Therefore, PE training such as Linked Bouldering Circuits (LBCs) or Route Intervals should be used to train for onsighting. Again, to improve the specificity for onsighting, PE exercises should be performed at a slower pace, on holds and angles similar to the climber’s onsight limit, rather than redpoint limit terrain. Thus, while an LBC geared for redpointing may last one and a half to two minutes and include three boulder problems totaling 20 intense hand moves, an onsight-focused LBC might aim to complete 20 slightly easier moves in two and a half to three minutes. The selected LBC might even offer the possibility to shake out at poor rests. If possible, perform the LBCs on problems you don’t know well (which can complicate the problem-selection process).

Many of the physical skills necessary for limit onsights can be obtained within the confines of a red-

point-centric training program, but if onsight climbing is the highest priority, the training program should be adjusted to favor these desired outcomes. Others place the highest priority on redpoint climbing, mixing in onsights occasionally. When following the Rock Prodigy training program, the ideal fitness for onsighting typically arises near the end of the Performance Phase. This is when endurance, technical skill, and familiarity with lead climbing and falling are all at their peak — ideal for most limit onsights. However, onsights of short, powerful routes (or routes with short cruxes split by excellent rests) should be attempted in the first two weeks of the Performance Phase, when power is highest.

MENTAL PREPARATION

For a climber who has decent fitness for redpointing, onsighting is primarily a mental test. Forearm endurance can easily be undermined by a poor mental state, leading to poor breathing, tunnel vision, misreading sequences, inefficient movement, over-gripping, and eventually pumping out. This can’t be overstated: Great endurance only helps the climber who is able to climb efficiently, without over-gripping! A well-trained climber who panics on a climb, stops breathing, and over-grips will fail every time.

These behaviors generally result from the climber’s own assessment that the route is too hard for him and failure is likely. This makes the climber tense, causing him to over-grip throughout the climb, wasting energy and exacerbating the pump. His movements will be rigid and static rather than flowing and smooth, because he is constantly anticipating retreat or afraid of what is to come. He doesn’t believe there will be rests so he’s in constant fear of pumping off. When a crux arises, he’s likely to rush through it too quickly because he’s certain climbing slower will make him pump off. If the climber attempts a sequence incorrectly, he is likely to doggedly persist, assuming that it is the correct sequence and he is simply not strong enough to climb it. Instead of this attitude of “impending doom,” climbers should seek a mental state in which they are relaxed and confident enough to remain calm when faced with adversity, but ready to spring into action with decisive effort when needed — call it “cautious optimism.”

“Mountains have a way of dealing with overconfidence.” — Hermann Buhl¹

Onsight Climbing with a Fear of Falling

Climbers who struggle with a fear of taking lead falls must address this issue before utilizing the other techniques discussed in this chapter. All of the challenges of onsighting pale in comparison to dealing with a fear of falling. The calm mental state needed for difficult onsights cannot be achieved by someone who is preoccupied by a fear of falling. That is not to say that such climbers should not attempt onsights, but they should realize that the set of challenges facing them on an onsight is different than what is addressed here. Climbers who fear leading and taking lead falls would do well to read Arno Ilgner's groundbreaking *The Rock Warriors Way*,⁵ and then return to the subject of improving at onsight climbing when they are not handicapped by anxiety over falling.



Onsight climbers must be willing to go for it at any moment, without regard to falling anxiety. Cheryl Pirozzi feeling the heat on *Tacos Diablos*, 5.13a, Alta, UT.  Brendan Nicholson

Cautious optimism describes an attitude in which the climber feels that there is a high likelihood of success on the route, but also understands that it will be hard and a great effort will be required. Still, he believes that he will rise to the occasion and succeed. Therefore, the climber must have the confident belief that he is skilled enough to send the route, something a climber can't lie to himself about. This confidence imparts several advantages during an onsight. It imparts a belief that the climber can recover if a mistake is made, and a belief that he will find the correct sequence through the crux. This relaxed mental state makes it easier to take the climbing as it comes and solve movement problems as they present themselves. In a sense, it is a self-fulfilling prophecy: If the climber believes that the onsight is possible, or even likely, then it just might be. That belief enables the climber to remain calm and relaxed, climb most efficiently, and thus handle the physical challenges. On the other hand, when a climber believes the onsight is not possible, or even unlikely, it most certainly will be.

Unfortunately, there is no easy road to acquiring this confidence. It is a result of your self-image, and thus a result of your true accomplishments (not including whatever "fish tales" you may relate to your mates). A climber builds that confidence by building his accomplishments through an onsight-specific route

pyramid (see [Chapter 2: Goal Setting and Planning](#)). A climber contemplating a 5.12a onsight attempt has tangible confidence if he has onsighted other 5.12a's, or many 5.11d's, especially if they are of similar styles and at the same crag as his target onsight route.

Onsight pyramids should begin humbly, with routes well below the climber's limit, because there is only one shot to onsight each route. Work to build a substantial base at each grade before moving up to the next. Therefore, an onsight pyramid should be flatter than a redpoint pyramid, and it should only be composed of outdoor routes on real rock. The nature of gym climbing eliminates most of the challenges of onsighting, so these routes will not build the necessary skills for onsighting on rock. Given the variety of climbing styles, it is also advisable to build pyramids for each rock type or crag; for example, a climber might track separate route pyramids for granite, sandstone, and limestone sport climbing. You shouldn't expect your onsight prowess to immediately transfer to a new crag, so again, start humbly with a route pyramid to learn the peculiarities of the new crag (e.g., weather conditions, unique techniques, rock friction and foothold confidence), then gradually ratchet up the difficulty as familiarity grows and confidence builds. This will be the best use of time on a road trip and will set the climber up for success on limit onsights later

Replacing Your Misplaced Calm

One thing I've learned through experience and careful observation is that I tend to hold my breath during strenuous moves, especially dynamic moves. While this by itself isn't too terrible, the real problem is that I forget to restart breathing after the tough move or dyno ends. My breathing throughout the climb will dramatically shift from slow, deep breathing before the move, to shallow, inadequate breathing after — up until the point where I over-grip, get pumped, and fall off. I've had success overcoming this with a simple drill I call *Finding Calm* (see [Chapter 3: Skill Development](#)). This drill is easy to practice during ARC sessions.

Plan your ARC terrain to incorporate several dynamic moves. Take some time to perform these dynos during each ARC set. Consciously force yourself to pause after every dyno and re-start your breathing with slow, deep breaths. Also deliberately relax your grip, force weight onto your feet, and if possible shake out. It is very helpful to have a partner observe you because it is so easy to forget to do this after every hard move. As with any new skill, you must transition it to real rock climbing for it to be useful. Therefore, as the drill gets easier during your ARC workouts, incorporate it into more realistic scenarios: PE training exercises, outdoor warm-up routes, and eventually difficult redpoints and onsights. With directed practice, the bad habit of breath holding can be reduced or even eliminated.

— Mike Anderson

in the trip, when success is most likely. For onsights of a specific route you highly covet, it would be prudent to log several onsights at that grade before the pivotal attempt. Still, be certain to try eventually — failure is guaranteed if you never give it a go.

PREPARING FOR AN ONSIGHT ATTEMPT

After all of the training and preparation, it is time to go for the onsight. The first step is to select an appropriate route, but which routes make for good onsight opportunities? While climbers often joke about routes that they are “saving for an onsight,” some do hold climbs in reserve for many years without an attempt, hoping to onsight them at some time in the future. Climbers do this because ideal onsight routes are often few and far between, especially at certain crags or on certain rock types. The best candidates for onsights are heavily chalked routes, preferably sporting

fixed draws. Routes with low crux sections are also a good choice, because they are easy to scout from the ground. A good onsight candidate is of consistent, sustained difficulty, and thus lacks tricky, hard-to-read, stopper crux moves. Routes like these are generally very popular, and are thus easy to spot at most crags. Most of all, the ideal onsight routes are brilliant, magnificent routes that beg to be climbed and will inspire a great performance.

Once a route has been earmarked for an onsight attempt, very specific preparations should take place. It's best to set aside climbing days specifically for onsighting. The preparations for limit onsights and limit redpoints are distinct enough that combining both in the same day will leave the climber inadequately prepared for one or both. First, be clear with yourself and your partners that the intention is to onsight the route. Commit decisively to that goal. If the attempt is unsuccessful, you can return for a redpoint, but at least commit that first attempt to an all-out effort for the once-in-a-lifetime chance at the onsight. Anything less than total commitment to that attempt will lead to indecision once on the route and less than 100 percent effort when it is needed. The belayer should be in the loop about the onsight attempt to give the correct encouragement, and notify bystanders that the climber doesn't want beta shouted from below.

Warming up for a limit onsight should be slightly different than that for a redpoint. Perform a warm-up that's slightly longer than normal to dial in balance and footwork, because onsight climbing depends so heavily on movement skills. While the warm-up should include a standard progression of increasingly difficult routes to prepare the body, the mind needs preparation too. Therefore, if possible, the warm-up should include easier onsights so that you can practice the unique physical and mental skills required for onsighting. This will gradually build the climber's confidence, and create an opportunity to assess whether or not he or she is ready for the goal route.

Finally, just before an onsight attempt, the climb should be reconnoitered, as described below. A reconnaissance may go on for years before climbing a particular route, but at a minimum, it should be scouted throughout the warm-up, leading up to the attempt, with a final, thorough recon just before tying in. The climber should have a general strategy for the route, with specific plans for navigating the seeming crux sections. Discuss these with the belayer so he or she will know when to expect rests, when falls are more likely, and when maximum encouragement will be appreciated.



Routes that are heavily chalked, with fixed draws make good candidates for onsighting. Mike Anderson defying the laws of gravity to onsight 40 *Oz of Justice*, 5.13a, at the Red River Gorge, KY. Dan Brayack

ROUTE RECONNAISSANCE

The ability to anticipate the necessary climbing movements, or to *read* the climb, is a critical skill for onsighting. This process occurs on the ground, before an onsight attempt, but it also goes on continuously throughout the ascent. Climbers read routes from the ground routinely in the climbing gym, especially while bouldering, where it is typically easy to see all the holds. Generally a climber begins by visualizing the starting hand positions, and then imagining the sequence of hand movements leading to the top. Depending on the complexity of the route-setting, this

may be very straightforward in a climbing gym, but it is much more difficult on real rock, where there are many more holds to choose from, they are more difficult to see, and they often look very similar. Bring a cheap pair of binoculars to the crag, and use them to help identify holds from the ground. Furthermore, the holds on a real climb do not necessarily follow a logical, manmade pattern, so the moves may be much more complex. Additionally, reading an entire route requires analyzing an order of magnitude more movements than what you encounter on a gym boulder problem. Fortunately, there are a few techniques to simplify the process.

Hot Flashes

This chapter focuses mostly on onsight climbing, so if attempting a flash ascent (climbing a route first try with beta from other climbers), consider these tweaks:

- When receiving beta from another climber, be cognizant of physical differences such as reach, as well as strengths and weaknesses. Bubba's beta may not fit Suzie.
- Consider the pros and cons of using beta from a long-term projector vs "second-try guy." The long-term projector probably knows the best sequence, but unless he can boil it down to a few easy-to-remember sentences, the information may be overwhelming.
- If a running "spray-down" is available, take it! If you disagree on the suggested sequence once on the route, just bear down and execute the moves as instructed. Let the mind focus on breathing and relaxation.
- If nothing else, learn the *locations* of cruxes and rest positions. Beyond that, the most useful information to obtain is the proper *sequences* for the cruxes.
- The Internet is full of climbing videos. Just about every route worth climbing has been filmed. Find some video footage and study it before the ascent if possible.



Before an onsight attempt, carefully inspect the route and anticipate the climbing sequences. Fred Gomez anticipating a *Wild Gift*, 5.12c, RRG, KY.

The first step is to break the route into sections that can be more easily digested (or *chunk* it). Routes vary, but it's often logical to chunk the route by bolt locations, or apparent rest stances. Start by simply judging if each section will be easy or hard. Easy sections should be simple to identify — e.g., those that are less steep or those that are densely packed with good holds. Don't be fooled by easy-looking sections high on a route, where it can be difficult to judge the distances between holds. Two good holds that seemed a short span from each other when looking up from the ground could turn out to be part of a difficult crux. Sections of difficult climbing will have smaller holds, and generally fewer of them. Other cues, such as the quantity of chalk, may reveal where cruxes are. An increase in tick marks or a heavily chalked rest hold just before a thin-looking section may indicate a crux. On a route with fixed draws, an especially worn carabiner (indicating the site of many falls) or extended draws may hint at hard climbing to come.

Once the route is chunked, identify the sections that appear easy enough to be climbed onsight without detailed reconnaissance. These sections should be scanned for potential rest stances and superficially sequenced (hands only, perhaps) to catch any potential "gotchas." Otherwise, don't expend much effort meticulously sequencing these sections. The sequences are likely to be forgotten anyway, and that memory will be put to better use elsewhere on the route. Note the rest opportunities, and move on to the crux sections.

For crux sections, the goal is to create potential sequence options. The most basic planning is to decide which hands will use which holds, and in which order. Spend time analyzing each handhold. The locations of tick marks or thumbprints on the rock can be critical clues as to how best to use a given hold. This information will help decipher a sequence. For exam-

ple, a horizontal edge with a prominent thumbprint to the lower left is used by most climbers with their right hand. Thumbprints are especially pronounced near pockets. Next, consider how each hold will be gripped: Is it a crimp, a pinch, or perhaps an undercling or sidepull? Identify if certain holds would be used best from certain angles, as not every hold is best used in a straight-down pull. Pockets in particular lend themselves to use as sidepulls and underclings.

Finally, identify the footholds that will be necessary to execute the crux moves. Remember, the merit of a particular foothold has more to do with its location than its size or shape. Opposition holds, such as underclings and sidepulls, require opposing footholds, so locate these and imagine using them. If these footholds aren't apparent, perhaps the assumed opposition sequence is not correct.

Once the holds are assessed individually, imagine the movements between them in an unbroken sequence. If a particular handhold combination can be identified, such as the right-hand edge mentioned above, work backward and forward from that point to fill in the gaps. Matching or shuffling moves may be required if a viable sequence can't be identified. Considering the hand and footholds together, determine if any unusual body positions will be necessary, such as backsteps or drop-knees. Recalling the chunks, ensure that a clear sequence is identified from the beginning of the chunk to the end. Preferably these chunks would end at a rest hold, or at a minimum, a hold large enough to match on, so that the sequence used for the next chunk is independent of the preceding chunk.

Once each section has been assessed and visualized, create a strategy for the route as a whole. Decide on a climbing pace for each chunk: Easier sections should be climbed more slowly, to conserve energy and cultivate the desired calm mental state, while hard sections will dictate a faster pace, to avoid pumping out. Identify where you'll rest and how you'll clip each bolt. Identify the most likely failure points on the route. These may be the hardest chunks, or moderately hard chunks high on the route where fatigue is a factor. Identify the rest positions immediately before and after each apparent crux, and assess the possibility of downclimbing to a rest if a planned sequence turns out to be incorrect. Focus on these crux sections last so that the planned sequences will be freshest in your memory.

Finally, the last step should be to completely visualize and mime the climbing of the route from bot-

tom to top, including clipping. The climber should do this at the same pace intended for the climb (rests can be abbreviated), while practicing good breathing — slow and deep. If done right, the climber's heart may race as she mimes the crux sections. This is great — it's an opportunity to practice breathing deeply and relaxing to regain the calm state that will be needed at the same point on the climb. At the top of the route, visualize clipping the chains and the gratification that will bring.

PERFORMING DURING AN ONSIGHT

Once on the route, the real mental challenge begins: managing the flow of effort to conserve energy throughout the climb, while poised to conjure superhuman effort to overcome cruxes. During a well-rehearsed redpoint, many climbers seek an *autopilot* state in which they robotically execute the moves, sparing their conscious mind to focus on relaxation and breathing. Onsighting is not that simple.

Onsight Literacy

Keep this checklist in mind (or better yet, in hand) when reading a route at the crag prior to an onsight attempt:

- Chunk the route into manageable sections, preferably separated by good rests.
- Sort the chunks into easy and hard categories. An increase in tick marks may indicate a crux, while a heavily chalked jug may signal a rest.
- In the easy chunks, look out for “gotchas” and identify rests, but don't otherwise over-analyze these sections.
- Spend your time and memory on the hard chunks; locate and assess the handholds — chalk patterns, such as thumbprints and tick marks, can give away sequences.
- Identify the crux footholds, focusing on those that are in the best location.
- Connect the holds to develop sequence options through the hard chunks, ensuring a continuous sequence from the start of the chunk to its end.
- Once the chunks are planned, create a strategy for the route as whole, including pacing, resting, likely falls, and possible downclimb points. Discuss these with the belayer.
- Finally, mime the route from bottom to top, with appropriate pace and breathing, and make sure to clip the chains when you send!

“Absolute strength is less important in climbing than the ability to unleash your strength at the right time...When Elie Chevieux onsighted the first 5.14 I do not think he could do a one-arm pull-up, but he knew how to read the rock and anticipate the moves with incredible intuition.” — Fred Nicole²

Along with route-finding and sequence problem-solving, the onsighting climber must consciously ration effort throughout the climb, and adjust the pace of climbing through each section. The climber should already have a plan for this, but the route may dictate real-time adjustments. When a rest comes, the climber will need to explore and assess the quality of it in order to decide how long to spend there (use the MSS as a guide). When first arriving at a rest on route, look for ways to improve the rest (various hand positions, hidden holds, thumb catches, scumming other body parts, etc.). After four to five shakeout cycles, pick the best, most relaxing rest position and stick with it, because rests often become more restful with practice, as confidence in the footholds grows and the grip relaxes.

While actively engaging in problem-solving, it is essential to keep an emphasis on relaxation ongoing in the background. Accomplish this primarily through deep breathing, which should begin *before* the climb starts — while tying in. Deep breaths will keep the heart rate low, force slower climbing, and encourage a relaxed grip. The belayer should monitor the climber's breathing throughout the climb (requiring loud breathing on the part of the climber!), reminding her to “breath deep,” especially after dynos or crux sections when the climber is likely to tense up and lose focus.

Recall the desired attitude of cautious optimism. As challenging sections materialize on the climb, be confident that a solution will present itself. If a move feels overly difficult, perhaps you've missed something: a key foothold, a different way of grabbing a handhold, a different body position — don't automatically assume that the move should be as hard as it initially feels. Some moves, such as long dynos, are irreversible, and thus very committing. Only make such moves as a last resort. These moves can often be completed with a lock-off, or a slow dyno or deadpoint that gives the climber a chance to remain on the rock and try again in the event the dyno fails. Dynoing

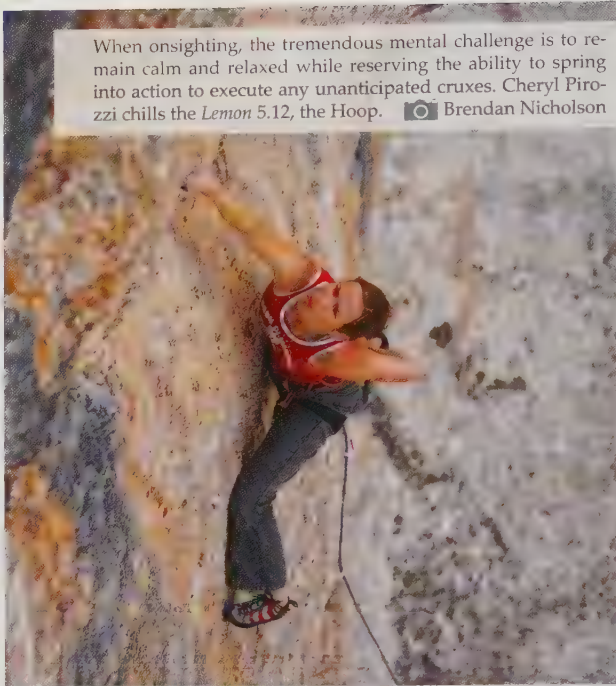
to an unknown hold gives the climber very little time to assess the best way to grip the hold, so if the move can be slowed at all, the chances of successfully latching the hold increase significantly.

In many cases, when faced with a perplexing crux, it is best to downclimb to the closest rest rather than forge ahead with a poor plan and weakening body. It's not unheard of for a skilled onsight climber to downclimb past multiple bolts to reach a good rest, resulting in a successful onsight. Whether and how far to downclimb always depend on the situation, but take into account the desperation of the current perch, the quality of any available rest, and the likelihood of making it there. Downclimbing to a good rest that is likely to be reached is never a bad choice, because a well-trained climber can achieve nearly full recovery, with patience, and will cultivate a better mental state in the process.

Generally, an onsighting climber should seek to approach the style of climbing used on hard redpoints: flowing movement that is not too static but also not out of control. Novel moves will be encountered, but they should be similar to moves the climber has done hundreds of times. Don't overanalyze them; the body remembers how to climb these moves, so let it do so. Intensive, conscious pre-analysis of moves should be a last resort, reserved for the most perplexing cruxes, and preferably only performed from a good rest position. Consider a trail runner: She doesn't pre-plan every foot placement and muscle movement; she flows along the trail, calling on years of practice to make thousands of subconscious decisions on the fly, only thinking consciously when faced with extraordinary obstacles like a large rock or downed tree. Throughout the climb, use deep, regular breathing, slow but flowing (not jerky) movement, and a relaxed grip. The conscious mind should be reserved to focus on the pressing issues of pacing, rationing effort, and active problem-solving.

Inevitably, a limit onsight will require a decisive moment, when the moves are too difficult to climb in this flowing, Zen-like state. These are the make-or-break moments when the climber must bust out some hard moves. In these cases the climber should not expect easy climbing, but should be confident that he has a good shot at sticking the moves. He should then investigate all of the possibilities to flow past the crux before deciding to go for it. Realizing there is only one chance, the climber should resolve to climb in a manner he won't regret later — and to try hard! When engaged in a desperate crux section, don't dillydally.

When onsighting, the tremendous mental challenge is to remain calm and relaxed while reserving the ability to spring into action to execute any unanticipated cruxes. Cheryl Pirozzi chills the *Lemon 5.12*, the Hoop.  Brendan Nicholson

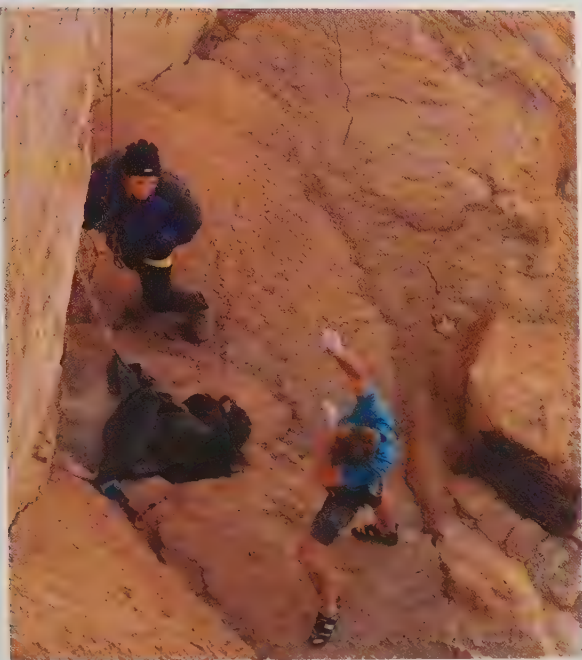


There should be a plan before setting out, so execute the plan as quickly as possible. Don't try to milk every hold to get a better grip; if you stick the hold, move on to the next one and get through the crux. It's going to feel awkward and hard (especially during an onsight), but this is what makes the route challenging — deliberately savor the challenge, and don't try to avoid or delay it! Once past the crux, it is critical to return back to the state of calm efficiency in order to complete the remainder of the route and cruise to the chains.

PERFORMANCE REVIEW

A difficult onsight attempt should be reviewed and evaluated immediately after the effort, just like a difficult redpoint attempt (see “Performance Review” in **Chapter 12: Preparing to Perform**). Due to the unique mental requirements of onsighting, there is an even greater opportunity for improvement by conducting a thorough, honest evaluation of how your mental state evolved during the climb. Most of the evaluation criteria used for redpoints apply to onsight attempts. In addition to those, also consider:

- How did your mental state, and its evolution during the climb, differ from what is typically experienced on a limit redpoint?
- How did you react to uncertainty or deviations from the plan?
- How did the actual movements compare to the planned sequences developed during the reconnaissance?
- How can those differences inform future recons?



After every onsight or redpoint attempt, take time to evaluate the effort, review the moves, and note any lessons learned.

Mike Anderson

No Purchase Necessary, but Must Be Present to Win

Not to sound like a know-it-all, but you will never onsight the route you never try. It sounds painfully obvious, yet climbers make this mistake all the time. They assume they aren't capable of onsighting a certain grade, so they simply never try. This frequently happens with a route the climber has decided will be a redpoint project. They declare their first attempt a "working burn," and thus *plan* on hanging on the rope at the first opportunity. Why not forfeit one burn (there will be more) and give an all-out try for the onsight? Are you reluctant to "waste" a burn on an unlikely onsight attempt? Keep in mind, even if you fall, you're likely to gain critical knowledge that may be the key to eventual success. Maybe you'll get "lucky" — more accurately, maybe your low expectations and "nothing to lose" attitude will enable you to climb better than you normally would on a high-stakes onsight. Maybe you'll succeed; you'll never know if you don't try.

SUMMARY

- Structured training is the most effective use of time and effort for continuous improvement, but it's also necessary to apply effort at the crag, during performances, to realize those improvements.
- For the fastest and surest long-term improvement, it is best to select redpoint projects that can be completed in five climbing days or less. This approach exposes the climber to more routes over the long term, and thus a wider variety of climbing styles, movements, and challenges.
- During a short-term redpoint, the challenge is to learn the moves quickly and move on to redpoint attempts. Therefore, it isn't necessary to perfect every move — focus on learning the cruxes and the final pumpy run to the chains (when applicable).
- Long-term redpoint projects should be attempted only rarely (such as when a dream route is within reach). Consider the location, your strengths and weaknesses, and level of inspiration when selecting a mega-project.
- A long-term redpoint will have very hard cruxes, so work on these moves early in the process, early each day, and early each burn. It's also helpful to target training to the route.
- Once committed to a long-term project, see it through to a logical conclusion and enjoy the process. Split the route into believable segments, set achievable goals for each day, and try to make tangible progress each day. Take a break or a long hiatus once progress stagnates.
- Onsighting is the ultimate expression of climbing mastery. There is only one chance for success, so it requires the climber to be completely prepared before the ascent. Developing a broad repertoire of climbing moves and techniques is the best preparation.
- Onsighting generally requires more endurance than redpoint climbing, to allow time for the climber to discover the moves as he climbs. Rely on the body's natural climbing instincts and don't try to analyze every last, trivial move.
- The climber's mental attitude is critical to onsight climbing. Be cautiously optimistic and have confidence that success is possible, but be ready to exert great effort when needed. Evaluate and learn from every onsight attempt, and use the experience to develop as a climber.